Green Space, Public Safety, and Public Services: Three Lessons from European Cities for a More Livable Indonesia

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Urbanization in Indonesia is moving fast. More than half the population now lives in cities, and that share keeps climbing every year. Unfortunately, a growing city doesn't automatically mean a better life for the people living in it. Quality of life (QoL) often lags behind the pace of physical urban development.

To make sense of this gap, this essay draws on three sources: the OECD's country page for Indonesia (OECD, n.d.-a), the OECD Regional Well-Being framework (OECD, n.d.-b), and the Quality of Life in European Cities 2015 survey (European Commission, 2016). None of these are meant to place Indonesia in direct comparison with OECD or European countries; rather, they serve as a reference point for thinking about where Indonesian urban policy should be heading. Of everything these three sources offer, three lessons stood out to me as most relevant: green space, public safety, and public services.

In the OECD Regional Well-Being framework, the environment is one of eleven core dimensions used to compare well-being across 467 regions in OECD countries (OECD, n.d.-b). The Quality of Life in European Cities 2015 survey consistently lists the availability of green space and public space as a key driver of resident satisfaction (European Commission, 2016). It's no surprise, then, that the European cities surveyed generally report high satisfaction with well-maintained parks that are easy to reach on foot.

Indonesia tells a different story. Jakarta, Surabaya, Bandung, and many other large cities still fall short of the minimum 30 percent green open space mandated by the Spatial Planning Law. What Europe's experience makes clear is that green space isn't just a nice-to-have or a cosmetic feature; it is a genuine well-being indicator, one that shapes residents' mental health, the air they breathe every day, and how often they actually interact with their neighbors in shared public spaces.

Public safety also emerges as a fundamental component of QoL, not merely a matter of law enforcement. This shows up both in the safety dimension of the OECD Regional Well-Being framework (OECD, n.d.-b) and in the European survey's question about feeling safe walking alone at night (European Commission, 2016). Cities with high satisfaction scores tend to share a few things in common: adequate street lighting, public spaces that are busy and naturally watched over, and residents who trust their local institutions.

The picture in Indonesia is far more uneven. How safe people feel varies a great deal from one area to the next, shaped by traffic congestion, poorly lit alleys in dense neighborhoods, and unequal access to security services. Local governments might do well to consider perception-based indicators like the ones OECD (OECD, n.d.-b) and Eurobarometer (European Commission, 2016) use, which could help pinpoint trouble spots that official crime statistics tend to miss.

The Quality of Life in European Cities 2015 survey found that healthcare, employment, and education are the three issues European city residents care about most (European Commission, 2016). Investment in public transportation, meanwhile, has been shown to significantly boost resident satisfaction; in Budapest and Kraków, for instance, satisfaction with public transport reportedly rose by about 20 percent since the 2012 survey. This lines up with the OECD Well-being Data Monitor, which identifies access to services as one of the key pillars of well-being tracked across OECD member and partner countries (OECD, n.d.-c).

For Indonesia, these findings are worth weighing against the investments already underway, such as mass transit systems like the MRT and LRT, the expansion of the National Health Insurance program (Jaminan Kesehatan Nasional), and efforts to close the education quality gap between regions. That last point feels especially urgent outside Java, where uneven public services remain a structural challenge to development.

Taken together, these three sources point to one conclusion: improving QoL cannot be measured by economic growth alone. It requires indicators grounded in how residents actually perceive green space, safety, and public services. Indonesia is arguably well positioned to move in this direction, given that it already participates in eleven OECD bodies and has adopted fifteen OECD legal instruments (OECD, n.d.-a).

Going forward, Indonesia could adapt city-level satisfaction survey methodologies like Eurobarometer, while also drawing on the eleven dimensions of the OECD Regional Well-Being framework (OECD, n.d.-b) as a foundation for a regional well-being index. Doing so would let urban development policy focus more squarely on the quality of life residents actually feel, rather than just macro-level statistics on paper. A modest first step, such as regularly publishing citizen satisfaction indices at the city and regency level, could be a realistic starting point toward more livable Indonesian cities.

References

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